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Theses of Doctoral Dissertation

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Narratologies of Transmedia Networks

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1 AIMS OF THE DISSERTATION

The purpose of this research is to provide an expanded methodology for contemporary narratology that can explain, interpret, and analyze medially complex storytelling structures, while grounding itself in the theoretical field of classical structuralist narratology. While it is acknowledged that these foundational literary theories offer a precise vocabulary and toolkit for examining how stories are told, most of the prominent frameworks were forged with a single medium in mind. Our current narratives are decisively transmedial: stories are told across platforms, media, and formats, and interpretations emerge from the gaps between these fragments. The recipients of these works not only act as readers, but they also navigate, play, participate, and co-create. The central aim of this dissertation, therefore, is to extend the narratological approaches to create a more comprehensive framework so that it could describe, interpret, compare, and create transmedia works in a principled way, while also offering an analytical methodology – considering network metrics, mapping, and visualization – that scales to the size and complexity of vast storyworlds and transmedial narratives.

To this end, the dissertation develops a layered analytical framework that progresses from simpler forms of the literary to interactive and participatory practices. First, it reinterprets structuralist narratology (which is already an inherently transmedial approach) from a contemporary perspective, showing that core categories (e.g., order, duration, focalization, voice) remain analytically productive once reinterpreted for a discourse that unfolds across multiple media sites. This step is demonstrated and followed through a close analysis of the alternate reality game (ARG) *EverymanHYBRID*, where concepts inspired by Genette and Barthes are used to parse a networked corpus of videos, posts, and live events, without ignoring their medium-specific features.

Second, the framework integrates the layer of interactivity and agency by analyzing the recipient as a player. The dissertation adopts an integrative stance in the proverbial debate between narratologists and ludologists, treating play and narrative as complementary elements of the same system. The case of *SCP: Secret Files* – a video game embedded in the collaboratively authored SCP universe – ties this approach to the triad of “worldness”, mythos, topos, and ethos, and to the procedural analysis of game affordances. In doing so, the project establishes how the interactivity of game logics and narrative architecture jointly organize interpretation across a transmedia world.

Third, the dissertation adds a final layer of transmediality, encompassing the participatory co-creator and the holistic perspective of transmedia storytelling systems as networked structures, and argues for the interpretative value of visualization and metrics. By mapping story fragments and their relationships as nodes and edges, the method supports both distant and close readings: it identifies hubs, bridges, and meaningful clusters, and directs analytical attention towards the flow of narrative information as well. Here, the seminal ARG, *The Beast*, serves as a case study and proof of concept. The dissertation builds and analyzes the network of its sprawling corpus, utilizing centrality measures, morphological, and narratological (content-level) scrutiny. Among competing measures, betweenness centrality is justified as the most appropriate for narratological purposes because it captures brokerage – control over the passage of narrative information between regions of the storyworld – rather than mere popularity or proximity.

Across these layers, the overarching objective is conceptual clarity joined with methodological practicality. Conceptually, the work synthesizes a vocabulary that remains legible to literary

narratology while accommodating transmedia-specific phenomena (multi-site discourse, participatory traversal, ergodicity). Methodologically, it outlines a regenerable pipeline (data collection, data cleaning, encoding of relations, visualization, metric-driven interpretation, and morphological interpretation) that other researchers can adapt to different corpora, use to compare transmedia systems, and apply to professionals creating such sprawling storytelling structures. The cumulative effect is an analytical approach that can move fluidly between qualitative insight and quantitative structure – between local textual cues and global patterns of connectivity – without reducing either to the other.

The aims are deliberately interdisciplinary. The project inhabits the borderlands of literary studies, game studies, media theory, and network analysis, because contemporary transmedia narratives are themselves hybrid systems. Its case studies were chosen to reflect this hybridity.

In sum, the aim is to provide (1) a transmedially literate and contemporary extension of structuralist narratology that travels across platforms without losing conceptual precision; and (2) a transparent method that maps out transmedia storytelling systems – including network modeling and an argued choice of metrics – that enables scholars and practitioners to analyze complex story systems at a scale that is hard to grasp. By moving from structuralist reinterpretation, through agency and worldness, to network analysis, the dissertation offers a cohesive framework for understanding how contemporary stories are architected, how they guide recipients through multi-site discourse, and how their flow of information can be identified and interpreted.

2 MAIN THESES OF THE DISSERTATION

1. **Classical structuralist narratology is inherently transmedial** when reinterpreted in a contemporary media setting; its categories (order, duration/frequency, focalization, voice) operate across multi-site, multi-media discourse. These categories describe how narrative units and information circulate between platforms without loss of conceptual precision. Structuralist narratology thus supplies a portable baseline for cross-media analysis.
2. **Contemporary narratology is interdisciplinary by requirement.** All narratives of our contemporary media landscape feature interconnectedness, procedural conditions, and platform-conscious organization of information. A sufficient analysis must therefore coordinate structuralist discourse analysis, a study of interactivity and agency, media and platform analysis, and system/network modeling supported by transparent data practices.
3. **Contemporary storytelling is networked; narratology requires transmedial toolkits.** The unit of analysis is no longer a single item of narration but a distributed system of interlinked storytelling instances, pathways, and cues. Adequate explanation, therefore, demands models that capture linkage, directionality, entry/exit conditions, and the logistics of traversal.
4. **Recipient roles constitute a permeable triad** – reader, player, co-creator – stated as modes of engagement rather than fixed identities, and defined along three dimensions already: (a) interpretive work (what must be inferred/reconstructed from dispersed story fragments), (b) interactivity (what actions and procedures gate or sequence access), and (c) contribution to canon (who leaves durable story material that others must subsequently read or play). These dimensions are distributions, not labels: the same recipient may shift state within a single traversal.

5. **Transmedial narratives are systems and networks:** formally, a directed graph where nodes are narrative instances (videos, documents, novels, events) and edges are typed relations (embedding, reference, sequence/activation, associational), often time-stamped (hence ephemeral) and platform-constrained. This formalization yields more testable narratological claims: hubs and bridges are not metaphors but topological roles; betweenness metrics capture the control over information flow. Visualization is not decoration, but an analytical instrument for hypothesizing zones of narrative fragments, bottlenecks, and cue logistics, to be revisited in close reading. Examining vast interconnected narratives (e.g., *The Beast*) necessitates graph construction and metric scrutiny to reveal informational chokepoints and traversal strategies that are otherwise invisible at the surface level; the network model is therefore constitutive of explanations for transmedial works, not merely an optional summary.
6. **The scale of transmedial narrative networks necessitates network analysis and visualization.** Close reading alone cannot exhaustively map vast, evolving corpora; graph-based modeling and visualization are necessary scholarly instruments. Metrics – especially those that expose brokerage and flow – yield new interpretive perspectives, while visual layouts make complex architectures legible and comparable.
7. **Transmedial literacy is a civic competence:** in a networked media ecosystem where meaning is assembled from dispersed fragments and routed through multi-site discourse, citizens need narratological skills to map and evaluate networked storytelling. This literacy entails recognizing migratory cues and paratextual trail markers, tracing information flow and brokerage (who mediates access and sequencing), assessing authorship liability, and understanding how procedurality and interfaces condition what can be known, by whom, and when. Without these capacities, recipients are structurally vulnerable to manipulation through selective linkage, strategic cueing, and infrastructural opacity. With them, the same systemic architectures can be redirected toward collective sense-making and public value – designing, curating, and teaching for transparency, accountability, cultural memory, and participatory knowledge.

3 PUBLISHED RELEVANT WORKS

- Fejes, Richárd. “A Transzmédia-Diskurzus.” In *Transzmédia: Interdiszciplináris Tanulmányok*, edited by Richárd Fejes and Lilla Gregor. Digi Poszt. Kijárat Kiadó : I.T.E.M. Alapítvány, 2020.
- Fejes, Richárd. “Secure, Contain, Protect: Az SCP Foundation Transzmediális Univerzumának Jelenléte a Videójáték Médiumában.” *Filológiai Közöny*, no. 4 (2024): 41–60.
- Fejes, Richárd. “Would You Stop Changing My Games? Stop Adding Lampposts to Them? (Az Elbeszélő Diskurzus Struktúrái a Videójátékokban).” *Tiszatáj* LXXVI, no. 9 (2022): 76–89.
- Fejes, Richárd. ““Would You Stop Changing My Games?”: Structures of Narrative Discourse in Video Games.” In *Multidisciplinary Perspectives on Narrative Aesthetics in Video Games*, edited by Deniz Denizel, Deniz Eyüce Şansal, and Tuna Tetik. Peter Lang, 2021.
- Fejes, Richárd, and Lilla Gregor, eds. *Transzmédia: Interdiszciplináris Tanulmányok*. Digi Poszt. Kijárat Kiadó : I.T.E.M. Alapítvány, 2020.